

"Innumerable revolutions have taken place in all

Raja Ram Mohan Roy

Social reformer 1772-1833

# THE MODERNIST

Without this relentless crusader's intellectual stimulation and indefatigable campaigns against social evils like sati and child marriage, it is not possible to conceive of contemporary India

■ By S. B. Upadhyay

The 19th century was a period of great intellectual ferment in India. The colonial ideologies spawned by Orientalists, Utilitarians and other Western thinkers were fundamentally changing the terms of debate, forcing the traditional systems of intellectual and religious discourses in India into retreat or resistance. It was quite apparent to many Indian intellectuals that their own society and religious systems were beset with several evils. Superstition, bigotry, fatalism, polygamy, sati, child-marriage and infanticide were big hurdles in the progress of the country. These intellectuals realised that without modernising these customs, there was no hope for the Indian people. It goes to their credit that they mostly followed an independent line in criticising and attacking the superstitious, discriminatory and oppressive practices prevalent in the Indian society.

In this process, they took a far more radical stand than the colonial state was willing to countenance or implement due to fears of reprisals from the social and religious orthodoxes of various denominations. The new Indian intellectuals also had to face resistance, hatred, hostility and attack from the orthodox elements in their society. But they openly expressed their opinions and steadfastly pursued their activities, although quite circumscribed by the prevailing situation.

Ram Mohan Roy was the first

among such valiant fighters. Not surprisingly, he is also called the Father of Modern India. Without his intellectual stimulation, religious stand and indefatigable campaigns against certain social evils, it is not possible to imagine of a modern India.

Roy was born in Bengal in 1772 into a Vaishnavite family. His initiation was in Bangla and Sanskrit. After this, he went to Patna to learn Persian and Arabic. It was only later that he became versed in English, and, still later, in Greek and Hebrew. His reading of the Quran gave rise to his early monotheistic ideas. These views were clearly expressed in his first available writing, *Tuhfat-ul-Muhawaddin* (1803). Written in Persian, with an introduction in Arabic, this work was a devastating attack on superstitious rituals, and a belief in rationalism and unity of Godhead. His belief in rational thinking was so marked that he declared that "pure rationalism is our teacher", and that "he who will not reason is a bigot; he who cannot is a fool and he who does not is a slave". His belief in monotheism was strongly supported by his study of the Upanishads, some of which he translated into Bangla later on. In 1814, he founded the Atmiya Sabha (Friendly Society) to popularise rational religious ideas.

Roy is best known for his campaign for the abolition of sati. Because of his constant efforts, the then governor-general, William Bentinck, enacted law to ban it in 1829. But Roy's ideas on the empowerment of women were

not restricted to this. He attacked polygamy and the degraded state of widows, particularly in Hindu society. He spoke against child marriage and argued for widow remarriage. He advocated female education and the grant of property rights to women.

He severely criticised the division of Indian society into multiple castes: "I regret to say that the present system of religion adhered to by the Hindus is not well calculated to promote their political interest. The distinction of castes and innumerable divisions and sub-divisions among them, has deprived them of patriotic feeling, and the multitude of religious rites and ceremonies and the laws of purification have totally disqualified them from undertaking any difficult enterprise." In 1828, along with Dwarkanath Tagore, he founded the Brahmo Samaj to fight against social evils.

Roy believed that modern education was an important vehicle to carry social reforms and enlighten people about their rights. Thus, in 1817, along with Alexander Duff and David Hare, he set up the Hindu College at Kolkata.

Roy's advocacy of religious universalism is of great relevance even today as a social and religious counterpart of political secularism. The greatness of Ram Mohan Roy lies in the relevance of his ideas for contemporary Indian society, beset as it is with so many problems.

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